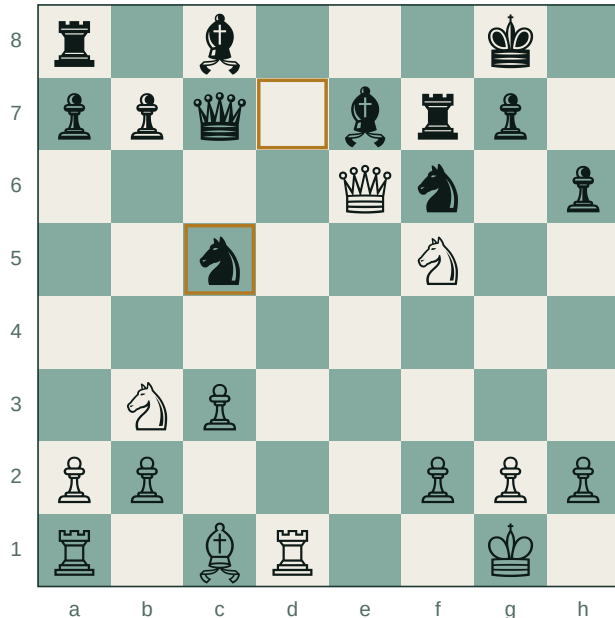


Capture the defender: White, move 18

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 17...Nc5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Nxe7+ Qxe7 19. Qxe7 Rxe7 20. Nxc5

18.Nxe7+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From e7 it attacks king on g8 and bishop on c8. Recorded reply: **18...Qxe7**.

19.Qxe7 The queen captures the queen on e7. From e7 it attacks rook on f7, knight on f6 and knight on c5. Recorded reply: **19...Rxe7**.

20.Nxc5 The knight captures the knight on c5.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Absolute pin: rook on f7.